Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

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THE MATCHLESS RESILIENCE OF INDIAN HANDLOOMS



Almost all ancient civilisations used handlooms but the manner in which this legendary craft has survived and thrived across India is without comparison.

Weaving of fabric was a way of life for many rural communities in India for hundreds of years until the early 19th century when the British introduced industrial looms.

As weaving became mechanised, handloom weavers gradually lost their traditional jobs.

Mahatma Gandhi's campaign for khadi reversed this trend, as it used khadi to promote Indian Independence and self-reliance. His determined campaign led to an increase in the demand for handlooms across India.

By the mid-20th century, handmade fabric had become a symbol of Indian culture.



Indian history of handlooms in postage stamps: powerloom 1923...



...handloom 1983

However, when globalisation took hold from the 1990s, modern power looms producing cheaper fabric dealt a new blow to handlooms. The reduced demand has since led to a steady rise in the price of handlooms, which are now seen as luxuries, out of the reach of most people. Gandhiji would have been dismayed.

It is telling that despite the cost constraints, India today produces 95% of the world’s handwoven production.

Miraculously, we have retained a precious skill in large measures that has been lost to much of the world.



The thread that unites the world

For example, many countries have outstanding traditional crafts, e.g. Turkish carpets, Italian Murano glass, Kenyan beaded Masai jewellery, Japanese paper craft, Moroccan pottery, to mention a very few; all handmade but in pockets of these regions.

It is only in India that every state of this vast country has its special signature handloom fabric.



Soft cotton double Ikat fabric of Odisha



Muga, the prized wild organic silk of Assam



Doubly precious, Bandhani on gajji silk, Gujarat



Mysore silk gets its sheen and suppleness from pure mulberry silk



The delicacy of the Maheshwari weave of Madhya Pradesh belies its strength



The intricacy of Banarasi brocade never fails to enthrall



The pride of Bengal, Jamdani cotton's distinct, geometric floral weaves have been recognised by UNESCO

Being a laborious craft of highly skilled artisans, the cost of handloom is naturally high compared to speedy powerloom, whose cheap imitations often make the case for handloom harder. For every original weave there is a pretend ikat, maheshwari, patola, baluchari and kancheepuram fabric, to name a very few.

It’s easy to see therefore why it is imperative to nurture and support handlooms, India’s national treasure. Besides being unique, they provide a livelihood to countless weaving communities and energise rural economies.



72% of India's handloom weavers are women

As a nation, we just need to seek, buy, use, wear and gift handlooms as a way of life so that demand rises and prices are no longer a concern.

A day will come, as it must, when powerloom simply cannot compete.